

Course milestone M1: Curiosity Committed and the Research Problem

HONR 46400 · Evidence-Driven Research

What to submit

One file, `lastname_m01.pdf`. Everything this milestone asks for goes inside it, as sections in the order below.

Submit it on Brightspace, under **Assignments** then **M01**. Brightspace carries the deadline.

This milestone presents **Book Milestone 1: Your curiosity, committed** (checkpoint, version 1) of the course book, EDR|AI.

What this course adds

Two things to add beyond the book milestone

1. **Prove your working setup runs.** Open this week's course notebook in Colab and save a copy to your own Drive. Run the readiness cell. It finishes with three ✓ marks: you can run a code cell, the course data loads, and you have claimed your copy by name. Paste one screenshot showing all three marks into your PDF. This is your proof that no later milestone stalls on setup. A setup problem you hide this week becomes a lost class hour later.
2. **Give a 30-second pitch at the Friday studio.** Say your research problem out loud, then name the real person for whom a different answer would be surprising. No slides. This is part of the grade, so time it once before class and keep it warm and short.

If you keep any code

Seed every code cell you keep with `SEED = 464`, and make sure the notebook reruns cleanly from top to bottom. A kept cell that does not rerun caps your verification score at the lowest band.

How these pieces are judged

Keep the whole artifact to about one or two pages, screenshot included. The screenshot and the pitch are both scored in the craft row: three legible ✓ marks and a pitch delivered on time earn full credit there.

Milestone 1: Your curiosity, committed

Open the milestone workbook in Colab

This chapter closes Studio 1: Begin with your curiosity. Its lessons each ended at **It is your turn**; what you wrote there arrives here as working material, and this is where the pieces become one artifact you can defend.

What this milestone produces. Your committed curiosity with its starting belief and the evidence that would revise it, the brainstormed candidates with what you kept and rejected and why, and one chosen research problem, scored and red-teamed, with your expected answer on record.

What you bring

Check you are carrying each of these before you start. If one is missing, go back and work that lesson's **It is your turn** first; the practice below assumes it.

- Lesson 1: From Curiosity to a Research Problem: your committed curiosity, the brainstormed candidates with NEW elements marked and kept or rejected with reasons, your chosen research problem scored and red-teamed, and your expected answer.

The practice

1. Copy your opening move's four lines as the artifact's version zero, dated.

2. Widen the curiosity: write two candidate directions yourself, then run the structured brainstorm and mark everything it introduced as NEW.
3. Choose the research problem and score it honestly on importance, feasibility, and contribution, one sentence each.
4. Write your expected answer and name one real person or role for whom a different answer would be genuinely surprising.
5. Keep the trail: candidates kept and rejected, each with its reason, and the NEW elements you adopted as your own.

A version, not a pass

Your milestone artifact is a dated, numbered **version** with the reason for the version attached. When later evidence changes it, you write the next version rather than editing the last one, because the sequence of changes is itself part of your research record.

The four rails, here

Four concerns cross every studio in this book. At this milestone they take these specific forms.

- **Ethics, permissions, and data exposure.** Note now whether chasing this curiosity would require people, and flag it before anything is designed.
- **Evidence, provenance, and reproducibility.** Your starting belief is a claim to check, not to defend; write it so evidence can move it.
- **AI activity, verification, and human decisions.** Brainstorm freely, and mark every AI stretch NEW; start a simple exchange log now, and Studio 2 turns it into your AI Research Ledger.
- **Uncertainty, claim boundary, and revision history.** Write what would change your mind while nothing is yet at stake; that sentence is the seed of every later boundary.

Where this milestone sits

This is the first of the book's twelve milestones. Milestone 2 sets the rules that protect this curiosity, opens the ledger that records every delegation, verifies your first AI assistance, and closes the arc by declaring your formal research question. The chain ends at Milestone 12: Your release and next cycle, where you decide whether your finished research artifact leaves your hands.

What sends you back

Studio 3's evidence map and Studio 4's diagnosis both send curiosity back here. A revised curiosity is progress on the record, not a restart.

How this milestone is assessed

Each row scores 0, 1, or 2. **10 points total.**

#	Criterion	0	1	2
1	The milestone artifact exists in full, specific to your own project	absent, or generic text that would fit any project	present but incomplete, or specific in some parts and generic in others	complete and unmistakably about your project
2	The milestone is written as a dated, numbered version with its reason	no version, or a version with no reason given	versioned, but the reason is decorative rather than an account of what changed	versioned with a reason a reader could use to reconstruct your thinking
3	Every judgment in the artifact is defended by you, not asserted by a tool	conclusions appear with no reasoning, or reproduce a tool's wording	reasoning present but thin where the decision was hardest	each judgment carries a reason you could defend under questioning
4	The four rails are carried in the form this studio requires	one or more rails absent where this studio required them	all rails present but one is nominal	every rail addressed in the form this studio requires

#	Criterion	0	1	2
5	The milestone's own product is present and defensible: Your committed curiosity with its starting belief and revising evidence, the brainstormed candidates with NEW elements marked and kept or rejected with reasons, and one chosen research problem, scored and red-teamed, with your expected answer on record	the milestone's own product is missing	present but would not survive a careful question	present and defensible as stated

Your workbook

Open the workbook with the link above. It walks these steps with a cell for each one, ends by writing your milestone version with its reason, and adds the rows this studio contributes to your AI Research Ledger and your Research Dossier.